How did the relative importance of 3 point field goals in NBA games change between the 1990s and the 2000s?

To evaluate how the importance of 3 point field goals changed between the 1990s (1990–1999) and the 2000s (2000–2009), I define importance using the percentage of total points scored from 3 point field goals. This metric directly measures how much 3 point shooting contributes to overall scoring, making it an effective way to assess its role in offensive strategy across time periods.

My analysis shows a substantial increase in the importance of 3 point shooting between the two decades. In the 1990s, approximately *12.08%* of all points scored came from 3 point field goals. In the 2000s, this increased to approximately *17.45%.* This represents an increase of over 5 percentage points, or roughly a 45% relative increase in the contribution of 3 point scoring to total offensive output.

This increase indicates a clear shift in how NBA teams approached offense. During the 1990s, scoring was more heavily concentrated on 2 point field goals and inside play. By the 2000s, teams increasingly relied on shooting from farther out, using 3 point field goals as a more central component of their scoring strategy. The rise in the proportion of scoring from 3 point shots suggests that teams not only attempted more 3 pointers but also structured their offenses to generate these opportunities more frequently.

The importance of 3 point field goals increased significantly from the 1990s to the 2000s, as shown by a substantial rise in the percentage of total scoring coming from 3 point shots.

Decade	Total 3pt Made	Total Points	% of points from 3
1990s	89,335	2,218,073	12.08%
2000s	138,370	2,379,091	17.45%

Appendix:

```
// -- -------------------------
// -- Part 2 Query
// -- -------------------------

// 1990's query:

db.games.aggregate([
  {$match: {date: {$gte: ISODate("1990-01-01"), $lt:
ISODate("2000-01-01")}}},
  {$unwind: "$box"},
  {$unwind: "$box.players"},
  {$group: {_id: null, total_3pt_made: {$sum:
"$box.players.fg3"}, total_points: {$sum: "$box.players.pts"}}},
  {$project: {_id: 0, total_3pt_made: 1, total_points: 1,
percent_points_from_3: {$multiply: [{$divide:
      [{$multiply: ["$total_3pt_made", 3]}, "$total_points"]},
100]}}}

])


// 2000's query:

db.games.aggregate([
  {$match: {date: {$gte: ISODate("2000-01-01"), $lt:
ISODate("2010-01-01")}}},
  {$unwind: "$box"},
  {$unwind: "$box.players"},
  {$group: {_id: null, total_3pt_made: {$sum:
"$box.players.fg3"}, total_points: {$sum: "$box.players.pts"}}},
  {$project: {_id: 0, total_3pt_made: 1, total_points: 1,
percent_points_from_3: {$multiply: [{$divide:
      [{$multiply: ["$total_3pt_made", 3]}, "$total_points"]},
100]}}}

])
```